During the past few years there has been a rapid permeation of British officials in Indian States, often thrust on an unwilling but helpless Ruler. The Government of India always exercised a great deal of control over the States from above; now in addition to this there is an internal grip on some of the most important States. So that when these States speak it is often the Government of India speaking with another voice, but taking full advantage of the feudal background.

I can understand that it is not always possible to indulge in the same activities in the States as elsewhere. Indeed, there are considerable differences—agrarian, industrial, communal, governmental—between the various British Indian provinces, and a uniform policy is not always feasible. But though action must depend on circumstances, our general policy should not vary in different localities, and what is bad in one place must be bad in another. Otherwise the charge will be made, and it has been made, that we have no consistent policy or principles, and all we are out for is to gain power for ourselves.

A great deal of criticism has been directed, and quite rightly, against separate electorates for religious and other minorities. It has been pointed out that they are quite inconsistent with democracy. It is, of course, not possible to have democracy, or what is called responsible government, if the electorate is divided up into watertight religious compartments. But the most earnest and persistent of the critics, like Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya and the leaders of the Hindu Mahasabha, are singularly acquiescent in regard to the conditions in the States, and are apparently prepared to have a federal union between the autocracy of the States and the democracy (so it is called) of the rest of India. A more incompatible and absurd union it is difficult to imagine, but this is swallowed without an effort by the champions of democracy and nationalism in the Hindu Mahasabha. We talk of logic and consistency, but our basic urges continue to be emotional.

And so I come back to the paradox of the Congress and the States. My mind travels to Thomas Paine and the phrase he used about Burke nearly a century and a half ago: "He pities the plumage, but forgets the dying bird." Gandhiji certainly never forgets the dying bird. But why so much insistence on the plumage?

More or less the same considerations apply to the taluqadari and big zamindari system. It hardly seems a matter for argument that this semi-feudal system is out of date and is a great hindrance to production and general progress. It conflicts even